Lebanon while fighting to restrict the president's constitutional powers as commander in chief.

We couldn't say no to those six small countries who had asked us for help. We'd have no credibility or standing in the Americas if we did. If it ever became known, which I knew it would, that we had turned them down, few of our friends around the world would trust us completely as an ally again.

I knew that if word of the rescue mission leaked out in advance, we'd hear this from some in Congress: "Sure, it's starting small, but once you make that first commitment, Grenada's going to become another Vietnam." Well, that wasn't true. And that's one reason why the rescue operation on Grenada was conducted in total secrecy. We didn't ask anybody, we just did it.

After giving my approval to the operation, I went back to sleep. After an hour or so, I got up to play golf. As I'd expected, my golf game needed some work. I hadn't played more than four times in the previous three years, and it showed.

When we reached the sixteenth hole, a group of Secret Service agents suddenly surrounded our group, stopped the golf game, and herded us into White House limousines. The situation was this: An armed man had smashed a pickup truck through a nearby gate at the course and taken seven hostages, including two White House assistants, to the pro shop. There he was threatening to kill them unless I agreed to meet with him.

Normally, I wouldn't have made any response to demands by a terrorist. That only encourages more terrorism. But I was told that the gunman was very unbalanced and the lives of the hostages were in imminent danger. I got on the car phone and called the pro shop, and when the phone was answered, I said: "Hello, this is Ronald Reagan . . ."

There was a silence, then the man hung up without saying a word and the phone went dead. We dialed the pro shop